ZIP 20852, North Bethesda and Rockville

The storm is not what kills people here. The chain that does is a power cut, then improvised heat or carbon monoxide, then an older person alone. Break it with a register, a CO alarm, and a named caller for the 2,824 people over 65 who live alone.

IMPACT REGION	EXCESS HEAT DEATHS	WINDOW	DOMINANT HAZARD
Montgomery County, Maryland (inferred, not resolved in the tool)	No figure published for the US, Maryland, or the county	Sep 2026 – Feb 2027 (6-month)	Winter cold, power outages, and carbon monoxide; a heavy snowstorm or none at all; flash flooding in stream corridors

14/14 recommendations checked. 12 corrected, 2 unverified, 0 contraindicated, 0 confirmed as written. Exposure figure: Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk*, September 2026, pre-peer-review. It publishes **no figure for the US**, so there is no national number to scale and none is given here. **The funding target fell by 43% in verification**, from $437k to $250k, and the shelter placement that the funding lens ranked first was cut to a contingency.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY — AT A GLANCE



39.05°N 77.11°W, United States of America · Natural Earth

- **The risk.** The chain that kills here is a power cut, then improvised heat or carbon monoxide, then an older person alone; 2,824 people over 65 live alone in this ZIP.
- **First action.** Montgomery County DHHS, Senior Connection, and the village networks build a list by 30 November of those 2,824 people and everyone on oxygen or powered equipment, with a named caller on cold-alert days and outages.
- **The money.** $110k floor, $250k target, $500k ceiling; the floor pays $70k for CO alarms and batteries and $40k for vaccination outreach.
- **Do not.** Do not heat with a grill, a generator, or the oven, or warm up in a car buried in snow: Maryland's carbon-monoxide emergency and urgent-care visits nearly doubled last winter, to 342.*

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* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

DOES EL NIÑO MATTER HERE? THE PREMISE, TESTED

Washington Reagan National (DCA) seasonal snowfall, NWS Sterling table. The 1991–2020 normal is **13.7 inches**.

STRONG EL NIÑO WINTER	SNOW (IN)	STRONG EL NIÑO WINTER	SNOW (IN)
1957–58	40.4	1991–92	6.6
1965–66	28.4	1997–98	0.1
1972–73	0.1	2015–16	22.2
1982–83	27.6	2023–24	8.0

- **Strong El Niño winters here are all or nothing.** NWS Sterling counts seven strong El Niños since 1950: four brought well-above-normal snow, and three brought virtually none. It calls the sample small. The snowiest winter on record, 2009–10 (56.1 inches), was a *moderate* event, not a strong one.
- **On average, strong events run warmer and wetter than normal.** On 8 October 2026 NOAA's Climate Prediction Center put a strong-to-very-strong El Niño as likely through January–March 2027 (over 83%), with a 70% chance of a very strong event in November–January. Its September winter outlook leans warm and, along the Atlantic coast, wet.
- **So the forecast cannot tell you whether you get a blizzard.** It can tell you to expect wet storms near freezing, which means ice, heavy snow, and outages. The deaths below happen whatever falls.
- **Who actually died last winter.** Maryland recorded **79 cold-related deaths in 2025–26**, a record: 58% were aged 65 or older, 39% died indoors, 2 died in vehicles, and 15% were recorded as homeless. Montgomery County had the fourth-highest count in the state. Carbon-monoxide emergency and urgent-care visits reached 342, up 95%, although two mass-exposure incidents inflated that count (Maryland Department of Health).

WHAT THIS PLACE SHOULD DO RANKED

Ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the winter peak. Backing lenses are shown per action. An action several lenses reached

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

independently is the stronger bet, but only where its evidence came from somewhere like here.

1. Build a list of the 2,824 people over 65 living alone and of everyone on oxygen or powered equipment, with a named caller on every cold-alert day and every outage

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · PUBLIC HEALTH · FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC · ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NO REGISTER PRECEDENT

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Montgomery County DHHS (Aging and Disability Services), with Senior Connection and the village networks	30 November 2026	Staff and volunteer time	Deaths indoors after an outage, and shutoffs for equipment-dependent households

ZIP 20852 has 48,180 residents, 8,284 of them aged 65 or over, and **2,824 one-person households headed by someone over 65** (ACS 2020–24, tables B01001 and B11007). That count excludes nursing-home residents. Enrol equipment users in **Pepco's Emergency Medical Equipment Notification Program**. Pepco itself advises them to be ready to relocate in an outage, so pair enrolment with a plan for where each person goes. File the Maryland PSC **Medical Certification Form**, signed by a physician, nurse practitioner, or physician assistant. It delays a shutoff by 30 days, is renewable, and requires a payment plan. Call each person on every county **Extreme Cold Alert** (below 32 °F, air temperature or wind chill) or **Cold Emergency Alert**, and during any outage.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Transferability: the outage evidence is from New York's August 2003 blackout, when accidental deaths rose 122% and other deaths 25% (Anderson and Bell, Epidemiology 2012). That was a heat event, so in winter the mechanism is cold and carbon monoxide instead. The medical certificate does not buy priority restoration, and it was not confirmed whether Pepco's program does. A county vulnerable-persons registry could not be confirmed either way. A "North Bethesda Village" was cited but could not be verified; Bethesda Metro Area Village is the nearest one confirmed.

2. Put a carbon-monoxide alarm in every older owner-occupied home that lacks one, and spread one message: no grills, generators, or ovens for heat, and clear the tailpipe before idling

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | SKEPTIC · PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Montgomery County Fire and Rescue (MCFRS) home-safety visits; 311 for alarm requests	**Before the first hard freeze, by 30 November**	**About $40 per alarm (market estimate); see the funding table**	**Carbon-monoxide deaths after outages and in snowbound cars**

County Bill 23-18, in force since 1 July 2019, requires CO alarms on every level of single-family, two-unit, and townhouse homes permitted before 2008 that have a fuel-burning appliance, a fireplace, or an attached garage. **It does not cover apartments.** Landlords supply alarms under other code, so target older homeowners. MCFRS already runs free home-safety visits and installs 10-year smoke alarms, prioritising older, disabled, and low-income residents. CO alarms have come only from donated stock, such as the 350 Pepco gave in 2024. This action expands an existing program rather than starting a new one. A CDC analysis puts the benefit-to-cost ratio of home CO alarms at **up to 7.2 to 1** (Ran, Nurmagambetov and Sircar, Am J Emerg Med 2018).*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The CDC figure is a national model and an upper bound. Buried-tailpipe deaths in the January 2016 blizzard were documented in New Jersey, New York, and Pennsylvania, not in Maryland.

3. RSV vaccine for everyone 75 and over (and at-risk 50–74), and high-dose flu vaccine for everyone 65 and over, aimed at people who don't already get it on site

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | PUBLIC HEALTH · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Montgomery County DHHS, pharmacies, and Charles E. Smith Life Communities	1 December 2026	Vaccine paid by Medicare Part B; outreach about $40k	Respiratory hospitalisation and death, the larger part of winter mortality

RSV vaccine is a **single lifetime dose**, recommended for everyone 75 and over and for people aged 50–74 at higher risk. It is not a yearly shot, so anyone vaccinated in 2023–25 is already covered. In the CDC's VISION network it was about 80% effective against hospitalisation (VISION network, Lancet 2024). High-dose flu vaccine had 24.2% higher relative efficacy than the standard dose in people over 65 (DiazGranados et al., NEJM 2014). The Charles E. Smith Life Communities campus (6121 Montrose Road, 20852) already has physicians on site, and its nursing home must offer flu vaccine under federal rules. **The gap is independent-living residents and people living alone at home**, so the money buys transport and homebound visits, not vaccine.*

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The effectiveness figures were confirmed from the verifier's memory of the papers, not re-fetched. Maryland's 65+ flu coverage could not be confirmed. Most excess winter deaths among people over 75 are certified as heart attacks, strokes, and infections, not hypothermia, which is why this ranks above warming sites.

4. Extend Rockville's senior snow-shovelling volunteers into the North Bethesda half of the ZIP, so older men stop clearing their own snow

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | FRONTLINE · SKEPTIC · PUBLIC HEALTH · HISTORIAN | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
City of Rockville senior services; Montgomery County Volunteer Center for unincorporated North Bethesda	Volunteers matched by 15 December 2026	Volunteer time	Heart-attack deaths after heavy snow

After 20 cm (8 inches) of snow, men's odds of dying of a heart attack the next day rose by **34% (OR 1.34, 95% CI 1.26–1.42)**, with no significant effect in women (Auger et al., CMAJ 2017, Quebec). Two Maryland men died shovelling in the January 2016 blizzard, in Fort Washington and Abingdon. The City of Rockville already matches volunteers to seniors and people with disabilities for shovelling. Prince George's County's "Operation Silver Shovel" served residents 70+ in January 2026, and about 4,000 households asked for help. No county-wide Montgomery program was found, so North Bethesda, which is unincorporated, is the gap.

The county's 24-hour sidewalk-clearing rule is reported second-hand and was not confirmed in the current code.

5. Name the warming sites that will stay open in a storm or an outage, and line up faith halls for nights

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · FRONTLINE · PUBLIC HEALTH | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Montgomery County DHHS and OEMHS, with congregations in 20852	1 December 2026	Not costed; see the shelter contingency	Deaths outdoors and in unheated homes during long outages

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The county's hypothermia page directs people to libraries, recreation centres, or a Ride On bus **"during normal operating hours"**, and lists no 24/7 warming site. It gives only a 24-hour phone line (240-907-2688). In a blizzard or a week-long outage, those are exactly the places that close. Publish named sites with generator power and staff, and give each a transport plan.*

This is the emergency manager's central point, and the gap is confirmed on the county's own page. What each site would cost was not established.

6. Close the gaps in energy assistance before the shutoff season: households not on SNAP, immigrant families, and anyone waiting on federal money

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST · PHILANTHROPIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Maryland DHS Office of Home Energy Programs; county DHHS; Washington Area Fuel Fund	Applications in by 1 November 2026	Within state programs; bridge grants in the funding table	Cold homes and winter shutoffs

Maryland already matches SNAP and TCA households into energy assistance automatically. It put $48M of state-funded supplemental grants out through September 2026 and raised benefits by up to 32% from 1 July for about 200,000 households. HB 1532 extends state aid to households that federal LIHEAP excludes, and a separate state program covers immigrant families. **So the action is the households outside the data match**, not a new enrolment drive. Between 1 November and 31 March, Pepco and Washington Gas may disconnect after a 24-hour affidavit. The only automatic bar is a 6 a.m. forecast of 32 °F or below. Federal LIHEAP is fragile: the last 10% of FY26 money was released only on 20 April 2026, and the FY27 budget proposes eliminating it. Whether FY27 money has been released could not be confirmed.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The Economist proposed asking the PSC to also bar shutoffs under ice-storm warnings. A rulemaking takes months and would not take effect before the peak, so the realistic route is a voluntary commitment from Pepco and Washington Gas. The PSC reported to the legislature on adjusting these thresholds in December 2024.

7. List every terrace-level and below-grade apartment along the stream corridors, sign residents up for Alert Montgomery at their home address, and plan a night-time way out

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | EMERGENCY MANAGER · HISTORIAN · FRONTLINE | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: US FLOOD-MAP ENTRIES ONLY

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
OEMHS, MCDOT and City of Rockville stormwater, property managers	15 November 2026	Not costed	Drowning in basement units during a cloudburst

On 1 September 2021, Ida's remnants dropped about 2.4 inches in 30 minutes on Rock Creek Woods Apartments at 13205 Twinbrook Parkway. That address is just over the line in ZIP 20851. A county box culvert was overwhelmed. Melkin Cedillo, 19, drowned in a ground-level unit trying to save his mother, and about 150 people were displaced from two buildings. The county's consultant called it a roughly 300-year event, and in September 2022 the county said it had **no immediate plans** to upgrade the culvert. Alert Montgomery lets residents subscribe by home address. Sign-ups should happen in Spanish, Chinese, and Persian at trusted venues (37.3% of 20852 residents are foreign-born), and organisers should never collect immigration status.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

It is unconfirmed whether Alert Montgomery can target a polygon from the sender's side; ask OEMHS. The in-language sign-up drive comes from the Frontline lens and was not separately verified. Its basis is documented immigrant distrust: in March 2026 testimony, the county's Community Action Board said many residents fear ICE contact.

8. Confirm backup power and a heating plan at every assisted-living home in 20852

UNVERIFIED | EMERGENCY MANAGER | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Maryland Office of Health Care Quality and the county fire marshal	30 November 2026	Inspection time	Residents losing heat in a long outage

Nursing homes are **already covered**: the 2016 CMS emergency-preparedness rule (42 CFR 483.73) requires alternate power to keep temperatures safe, plus a fuel plan, checked at inspection. Assisted living is outside that rule. Whether Maryland's assisted-living regulations (COMAR 10.07.14) require generators could not be verified, so this is the gap to check, not a known failure.

The emergency manager cited the county's 2012 derecho briefing as showing most nursing homes without power; that figure could not be re-read and is unverified. That was a July outage, so the plan needed now is a heating plan, not a cooling one.

9. Renters in ground-floor and terrace units: buy flood contents cover by 15 November

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | ECONOMIST | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: PRECEDENT (US FLOOD-INSURANCE REFORM)

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Households; county flood-preparedness portal to promote it	15 November 2026	Premium paid by the household	Uninsured loss of belongings

National Flood Insurance Program cover starts on the 30th day after purchase, so a policy bought after mid-November will not be in force for a December storm. FEMA reports, and the county repeats, that about a third of flood claims nationally in 2014–2024 came from outside high-risk zones.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Correction: **a policy barely covers contents in a true basement**, defined as any floor below ground on all sides; only a short list of items such as a washer or freezer is covered. A walk-out terrace unit may not count as a basement, so check each one with an agent. This protects belongings, not lives.

10. Hold Pepco to its existing reliability rules on 20852's worst feeders, and ask MCDOT to confirm battery backup on Rockville Pike and Old Georgetown Road signals

PARTIALLY CONFIRMED | HISTORIAN · EMERGENCY MANAGER | ADAPTATION INVENTORY: NONE FOUND

OWNER	BY WHEN	COST	PREVENTS
Maryland PSC, Pepco, MCDOT	Ask by 31 October 2026	Within Pepco's mandated programs	Longer outages and dark intersections

Maryland's reliability rules (COMAR 20.50.12) already require remediation of any feeder that appears on the worst-performing list three years running, and tree trimming on a four- or five-year cycle. Major rebuilds before December are not realistic, so the request is for compliance on the circuits that serve 20852.

The lenses' figures on feeder improvement (39% fewer outages) and the 2012 signal failures could not be confirmed, so they are not used. Whether MCDOT already has battery backup on these corridors is unknown.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

WHO DOES WHAT

RACI CHART

R = Responsible (does the work) · **A** = Accountable (one per action; signs off and answers for it) · **C** = Consulted (asked before) · **I** = Informed (told after). Built from the owners named in the verified actions. No one here has been contacted or has agreed to a role; every row is a proposal.

Action	County DHHS	MCFRS	OEMHS	MCDOT & Rockville stormwater	Rockville & Volunteer Center	Maryland (OHEP, PSC, OHCQ)	Pepco & Washington Gas	Care campuses & property managers	Senior Connection, villages, congregations	Residents
1. Register and named callers	**A/R**		**C**				**R**	**C**	**R**	**I**
2. CO alarms and the no-grill message		**A/R**					**C**		**R**	**R**
3. RSV and high-dose flu reach	**A/R**							**R**	**R**	**I**
4. Snow-shovelling volunteers					**A/R**				**R**	**I**
5. Storm-proof warming sites	**A/R**		**R**						**R**	**I**
6. Energy-assistance gaps	**R**					**A/R**	**C**		**R**	**R**
7. Terrace units and Alert Montgomery			**A/R**	**R**				**R**	**R**	**I**
8. Assisted-living backup heat		**R**				**A/R**		**R**		
9. Renters' flood cover			**C**					**C**		**A/R**
10. Feeders and signal backup				**R**		**A**	**R**			

What the chart shows. **County DHHS is accountable for three of the four rows that save the most lives**, so its aging-services team is the bottleneck for this winter. **The volunteer networks appear in seven rows**, more than any public body, which makes them the delivery system whether or not anyone funds them. **Residents are accountable for one decision only they can make**: buying flood cover before mid-November.

WHERE MONEY DOES THE MOST

FUNDING

The Philanthropist lens, reconciled against the ranked actions and verified. Placements are ranked by marginal lives saved per dollar. The envelope is bounded by what this ZIP can spend before the peak, not by what it needs.

FLOOR

$110k: CO alarms and batteries $70k + vaccination outreach $40k

TARGET

$250k: $70k + $40k + bill bridge $90k + shelter contingency $50k

CEILING

$500k: more battery units, and the bridge at $500 a household if WAFF confirms that cap

LARGEST UNCERTAINTY

Whether federal LIHEAP money for FY27 arrives on time, and how many Extreme Cold nights the winter brings

The lens proposed $437k (177 + 70 + 40 + 150). Verification cut it by 43%, which is more than a third. The shelter line ($177k) rested on a $177 "cost per bed night" that was the lens's own division of Interfaith Works' total homeless-services spending by its bed nights. That is not a

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

marginal price. The beds are county-wide, the county already funds hypothermia-season overflow, and only 15% of the state's cold deaths were homeless people. It becomes a $50k contingency, released only if county overflow is documented as full. The bill bridge was cut from $500 to $300 a household (300 × $300 = $90k), because no cap above the fund's historic average (about $175 a person) was found. Grants to county-wide recipients need a 20852 restriction in the grant letter.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
MCFRS home-safety program, with village networks	CO alarms for owner-occupied seniors (500 × $40 = $20k) and battery backup for powered medical equipment (50 × ~$1,000 = $50k) (actions 1, 2)	$70k	Pre-positioned stock	CO alarms: benefit-to-cost up to 7.2:1 (CDC, national model). Prices are market estimates. No recipient has run a battery-lending program before	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
Montgomery County DHHS and Senior Connection	Transport and homebound visits for RSV and high-dose flu vaccination (action 3)	$40k	Direct grant	High-dose flu was cost-saving against standard dose, −$115.92 per person (Chit et al., Lancet Infect Dis 2015, a Sanofi-authored analysis of a US and Canada trial). The lens's "$5,300–12,300 per QALY" is not in that paper and is dropped	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED
Washington Area Fuel Fund (Salvation Army) and Pepco customer relief	Bill bridge for 20852 households stuck in the federal or state queue (action 6)	$90k (300 × $300)	Top-up to an existing scheme	A 1% rise in heating prices raises winter deaths by 0.057%, more in low-income counties (Chirakijja, Jayachandran and Ong, NBER w25681). That is an elasticity, so deaths averted per grant cannot be derived. WAFF served 1,845 households in 2024, and it opens in January	PARTIALLY CONFIRMED

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

RECIPIENT	USE	AMOUNT	MECHANISM	BASIS	VERDICT
Interfaith Works	Hypothermia overflow and motel nights, only if county overflow is full (action 5)	$50k contingency	Standby grant on a Cold Emergency Alert	No published marginal cost per bed night. FY25: 975 people sheltered, 75,840 bed nights	UNVERIFIED

The funder's one thing: don't pay for what Medicare, the state energy programs, or the county overflow contract already cover. Pay for reach and speed: the alarm that isn't on the wall, the caller who knows the person, and the grant signed in October that pays out within 24 hours of the first alert.

Do not do this

CONTRAINDICATED · ADVICE THAT WOULD COST LIVES HERE

None of the recommended actions was found contraindicated. The items below are advice that circulates every winter and that the record shows costs lives.

Heating with a grill, a generator, or the oven, or warming up in a car buried in snow*

CONTRAINDICATED

Maryland's carbon-monoxide emergency and urgent-care visits nearly doubled last winter, to 342. In the January 2016 blizzard, people in New Jersey, New York, and Pennsylvania died in idling cars with their tailpipes blocked by snow.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Instead: run generators outdoors only, far from windows. Never use a grill or oven for heat. Clear the tailpipe before starting a car. Keep a battery CO alarm on every floor.

Telling older men to dig themselves out

CONTRAINDICATED

Men's odds of a fatal heart attack rose 34% the day after 20 cm of snow (Auger et al., CMAJ 2017). Two Maryland men died shovelling in the 2016 blizzard.

Instead: a volunteer or paid crew (action 4). If someone must shovel, push snow rather than lift it, and stop at any chest discomfort.

Making "go to a warming centre" the main cold-weather message

CONTRAINDICATED

The county's warming places close at night and in storms. Most of last winter's deaths were older people, many of them at home, while only 15% were homeless.

Instead: call people at home (action 1), and publish sites that stay open (action 5).

A snow-only campaign, or "stock up for a week"

CONTRAINDICATED

Three of the seven strong El Niño winters NWS counts since 1950 brought almost no snow. Low-income renters cannot buy a week of supplies in bulk.

Instead: plan for ice, outages, and cloudbursts as well as snow, and pre-position food through food banks and building managers.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

YEAR	EVENT	TOLL	WHAT CHANGED AFTER
1972–73, 1997–98	Strong El Niño winters with 0.1 inch of snow at DCA, the two least snowy on record	—	—
1982–83	Strong El Niño: 27.6 inches at DCA, most of it in the February 1983 blizzard	No local toll found	—
2009–10	Moderate El Niño: 56.1 inches, the DCA record	No local toll found	—
29 Jun 2012	Derecho, then a heat wave. Week-long outages across the county	The county briefing, as cited by two lenses, reports 1 death from a falling tree and 2–4 heat deaths. *Unverified: the briefing is a slide image and could not be re-read*	A PSC order on utility storm response; Maryland reliability rules followed
22–23 Jan 2016	Blizzard in a strong El Niño winter: 17.8 inches at DCA, 29.3 at Dulles	Two Maryland shovelling deaths (Prince George's and Harford)	—
1 Sep 2021	Ida's remnants: 2.4 inches in 30 minutes at Rock Creek Woods, Twinbrook (ZIP 20851, next door)	One death, a 19-year-old; about 150 displaced	None. The county planned no culvert upgrade (September 2022)
2024–25	Maryland cold season	69 deaths reported, later revised to 75; 36 outdoors, 13 homeless	—
2025–26	Maryland cold season, a record	79 deaths: 58% aged 65+, 39% indoors, 15% homeless; Montgomery 4th	Federal LIHEAP money withheld until April 2026

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

The recurrence nobody has noticed: this area does not get the forecast it fears. A strong El Niño gives DC either a famous storm or a bare winter, close to a coin toss. What repeats every winter, whatever falls, is older people dying at home. The other recurrence is a promise unkept: five years after Ida, the culvert that drowned a teenager next door has not been touched.

WHERE THE EXPERTS DISAGREE — RESOLVED AND OPEN

- **Shelter beds first** (Philanthropist) versus **housed older people first** (Skeptic, Public health, and the state's death data). Resolved toward the housed. Only 15% of Maryland's cold deaths were homeless people, and county overflow is already publicly funded. A $50k contingency keeps the shelter side covered if overflow fills.
- **Prepare for a big snowstorm** (Emergency manager, Historian) versus **prepare for rain and ice** (Skeptic). Resolved as both: NWS's record is four snowy winters in seven, and three nearly snowless.
- **A new rule barring shutoffs during ice-storm warnings** (Economist) versus **nothing passed now takes effect before the peak** (verification). Open. A voluntary commitment from Pepco and Washington Gas is the only route this winter.
- **Bridge grants now** versus **wait for federal LIHEAP**. Open. The fuel fund opens in January, after the cold has started, and whether FY27 federal money has been released is unknown.

WHAT NOBODY COVERED — BLIND SPOT

High-rises in an outage. The Pike corridor is lined with mid- and high-rise apartments and senior buildings, and no lens asked what happens when the power fails in them. Lifts stop, and water pumps and electric heat may go with them, leaving older residents on upper floors who cannot get down. No lens looked at **substance use** either, although 37% of last winter's cold deaths involved it. Either could change the ranking: a building-by-building outage plan might outrank actions 7–10.

HOW TO READ THIS — METHOD

The panel is author-built. Seven simulated expert lenses were used to generate these recommendations. Where they agree, that is a strong hypothesis, not a consensus of the field. Every recommendation was then independently checked for evidence, transferability to this location, and feasibility before the peak; the verdict tags carry the result.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

Mortality figures are resolved at Climate Impact Lab impact-region scale, roughly 300,000 people, and none is published for the US. The El Niño projection covers *heat only*; cold, outages, snow, and flooding are carried here by the historical record and Maryland's surveillance data rather than by a published projection.

HOW THIS BRIEFING WAS PRODUCED

METHODOLOGY

- **Scope.** The request named a street address, which was widened to its ZIP code, 20852 (about 48,000 people), to protect the requester's privacy and because ZIP-level data exists. The ZIP spans unincorporated North Bethesda (the White Flint / Pike District) and part of the City of Rockville. Climate Impact Lab impact region: inferred as Montgomery County, not resolved in the tool. Mortality figures exist only at that scale; ZIP and street detail is used for hazard exposure and action design.
- **Exposure.** Climate Impact Lab, *451,000 at Risk* (September 2026, pre-peer-review): ECMWF SEAS5 seasonal forecasts (51-member ensemble) applied to temperature–mortality relationships across 24,378 regions, against a 1996–2025 baseline, for June 2026 – February 2027. It covers heat only. It is never added to the Impact Map's long-run projections or quoted from the map's GDP-denominated mortality. Heat is not the dominant hazard here, so the historical record and state surveillance carry the hazard instead of a borrowed number.
- **Expert panel.** Seven simulated expert lenses (emergency manager, public health scientist, frontline responder, skeptic, economist, historian, and philanthropist) each researched this place independently and in parallel, from web sources, to a fixed brief.
- **Reconciliation.** Duplicate actions were merged and backing lenses recorded. Convergence was tested for shared bias (whether the evidence behind an agreed action came from a setting like this one) before it counted in an action's favour. Contradictions were kept, not resolved by dropping a side. Actions were ranked by expected lives saved per unit of effort before the peak, each was given a named payer and trigger or marked unfunded, and the funding placements were reconciled against the ranked list.
- **Verification.** Six separate verifier agents checked every recommendation on three tests: evidence (the primary source and its effect size), transferability (whether that evidence came from somewhere like here), and feasibility (whether it can be done here before the peak). Financial actions were also checked for availability in this jurisdiction, a named payer, a trigger threshold, and whether they already exist. The funding envelope was checked for real recipients, published unit costs, and duplication, then re-summed. The premise and the historical record had their own verifier.
- **Verdicts.** *Confirmed*: evidence, transferability, and feasibility all hold. *Partially confirmed*: holds after the corrections shown. *Unverified*: could not be checked to a primary source. *Contraindicated*: would do harm or waste the window here.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.

- **Adaptation Inventory.** Consulted by reading the dataset embedded in the inventory page. The relevant US entries are NWS winter weather advisories, which reduced crashes, especially with longer lead times (Anand, AEJ: Policy 2025); the mortality value of forecast accuracy (Shrader et al., NBER 2023); community health centres, which reduced heat deaths 14% but showed little effect on cold deaths (Mullins and White, 2020); and flood-insurance reform. Nothing in it covers CO alarms, outage registers, shovelling, or energy assistance.
- **Health wording.** Passages where a wording error could hurt someone (CO alarms, vaccines, warming sites, generators, and indoor heating) are marked "* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing." They were checked against published sources, not by a health professional. They are suggestions, not medical advice, and anyone passing them on should confirm them with a doctor, pharmacist, nurse, or community health worker first. The marker was added on 2 November 2026.
- **Rules.** No cost is derived by dividing a published total, and no local figure is invented; where data is thin, the report says so. The funding lens's $177 bed-night figure was such a division and is not used as a unit cost. Every source is listed below with its verification status.
- **Limits.** The panel and verifiers are AI research agents working from web-available sources, not human experts, and no one in 20852 was interviewed. Several verifiers exhausted their search budget, so some items are marked unverified rather than checked. The ACF LIHEAP page returned a 403 error, and the fuel fund's site would not load. Montgomery County's own cold-death count could not be read from the state report's chart (8 or 9). A 2026 homelessness count exists but was not retrieved. Rock Creek Woods is in 20851, adjacent to the ZIP, and is used as a precedent, not as an event inside it.

References · verified unless marked

Premise: NWS Sterling, El Niño and DC/Baltimore · NWS DCA seasonal snowfall · CPC ENSO discussion, 8 Oct 2026 · CPC seasonal outlook discussion · NWS January 2016 totals

Deaths and exposure: MDH 2025–26 cold report · MDH 2024–25 cold report · ACS 2020–24, ZCTA 20852 · North Bethesda CDP languages · Charles E. Smith Life Communities

Actions: Maryland medical certification · Anderson & Bell 2012 · County CO alarm law · MCFRS home-safety program · CDC CO-alarm benefit-cost · Auger et al. 2017 · Rockville senior shovelling · Operation Silver Shovel · County hypothermia page · Alert Montgomery · Rock Creek Woods, one year on · NFIP waiting period · COMAR 20.50.12 reliability · VISION RSV and DiazGranados flu figures (from the verifier's memory, not re-fetched)

Finance: Governor's energy assistance release · LIHEAP FY26/FY27 · COMAR 20.31.03.03 · PSC winter terminations report · WAFF · Interfaith Works FY25 · Chirakijja, Jayachandran & Ong · Chit et al., Lancet Infect Dis 2015 (PMID 26362172)

Exposure data · Climate Impact Lab, 451,000 at Risk · Impact Map · Adaptation Inventory

Generated 10 October 2026 for ZIP 20852, North Bethesda and Rockville, Maryland. El Niño Ready is volunteer-run and is not affiliated with Climate Week NYC, The Climate Group, or Columbia University.

* Suggested formulation: check with a health worker before sharing.